

BEFORE

In the 1780s, France faced a mounting crisis. A century of foreign wars had left the country with huge debts and threatened bankruptcy.

IMMEDIATE CAUSES

France's humiliation by England in the **Seven Years War** (1756–63) << 296–97, losing its North American colonies, motivated heavy French expenditure on the **American Revolution** (1775–83) << 298–99. Its effect was to put financial reform at the top of the political agenda. Under the *ancien régime* (pre-revolutionary “old order”), French society was divided into three estates: clergy, nobility, and commoners. Nearly 40 percent of the land was owned by the nobles and clergy who made up less than 3 percent of the population and were exempt from taxes, placing the tax burden on the bourgeoisie (middle class) and peasantry. Enlightenment ideas << 270–71 against tyranny led the growing professional classes to demand a greater role in the running of the country. Bad

harvests (1788–89) almost doubled the price of bread, worsening social tensions.

THE TENNIS COURT OATH

Louis XVI's attempts at economic reform were blocked by

his nobles, forcing him to summon the **Estates-General**, a parliament composed of clergy, nobility, and commoners, which had not met for 175 years. When it convened at the palace of Versailles in May 1789, the majority third estate insisted on greater voting rights, and when these were refused, broke away to form the **National Assembly**, inviting sympathetic nobles and clergy to join them. When they were locked out of Versailles on June 20, they reconvened in a nearby tennis court, where they swore “to remain united until a constitution is established.”



TAKING THE OATH

Revolution in France

A violent upheaval shook France at the end of the 18th century as several causes of disaffection came together at one explosive moment: national bankruptcy, the burgeoning ambitions of the bourgeoisie, the king's lack of authority, and growing social discontent caused by high taxes and rising bread prices.

The formation of the National Assembly on June 17, 1789 (see BEFORE) was the first step toward revolutionary change. Louis XVI's dismissal of Jacques Necker, the popular finance minister, on July 11, along with the concentration of troops outside Paris, provoked agitation in Paris for arms amid rumors of a royal clampdown. Several days of rioting ended with the July 14 capture of the Bastille prison (see pp.300–01), symbolizing an important blow against the oppressive forces of the *ancien régime*, while placing Paris and mob violence at the center of events.

The revolt spread to the countryside, where wild rumors resulted in the “Great Fear,” in which peasants attacked their landlords, burning their châteaux. On August 4, National Assembly deputies voted to abolish feudal privileges (see pp.190–91), sweeping away an entire system of

property ownership in one stroke. On October 5, Parisian women, frustrated by bread shortages and the king's indecision, marched to Versailles to force his move to Paris, where he could be more closely monitored.

Between 1789–91, the National Assembly passed a series of reforms that further undermined the *ancien régime*. These included publishing the “Declaration of the Rights of Man,”

reforming the army, dividing France into 83 *départements*, selling off the Church's land, and forcing the clergy to take a civic oath to the state. This last measure split the Church, alienating the conservative peasantry and sowing the seeds of future counterrevolution.

A new constitution showed the National Assembly's distrust of the masses by dividing the population into active (higher-income voting) and passive (non-voting) citizens.

This period also saw the growth of political clubs—such as the Cordeliers and Jacobins—that tried to exert pressure on the Assembly. The Jacobins were the first real political “party,” with clubs dotted throughout France.

In June 1791, the king attempted to flee abroad, but was captured at Varennes, east of Paris, by a postmaster. This marked a key turning point, for it lost the king his people's trust.

Threatened on all sides

In April 1792, a new Assembly declared war on Austria and Prussia, hoping to distract attention from

